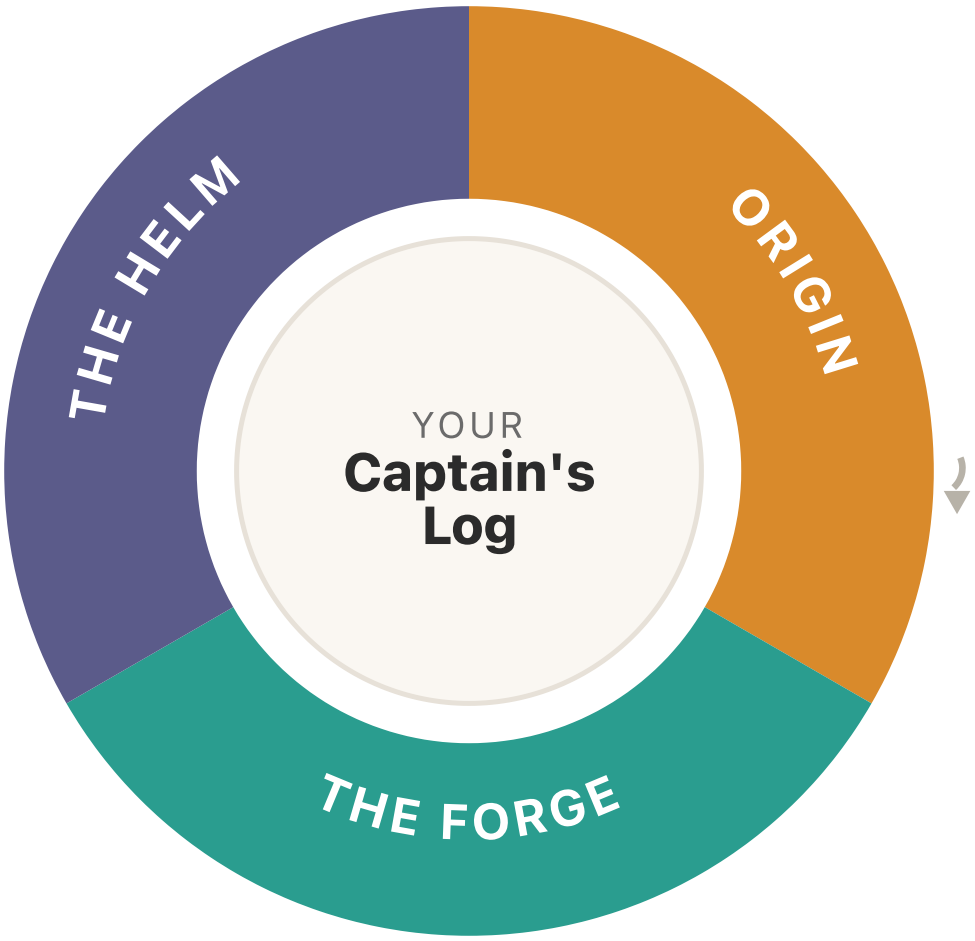
VIBRANT LIFE · A STUDIO FOR AGES 16 TO 18

The Launch Pad Story

Origin · The Forge · The Helm - a studio, not a high school

> We help young people become who they are meant to be - to know themselves, do work that matters, make the hard calls, and love the life they are living.



How to read the wheel

The program turns like seasons. Every learner walks all three seasons before they launch, and may join at any season - a learner who starts mid-cycle is joining the story in progress, never behind. Each learner carries one **Captain's Log** the whole way; it is the line they walk through the turning circle.

Your Next Great Adventure

A personal graduation send-off in each learner's final year, whatever season that is. The send-off belongs to the learner, not to the calendar.

THE SET-UP

Origin

Who am I?

JOY: ROOTS & BELONGING

- The Map of Me - 100 dreams
- The Lineage - family stories
- The Power of Choice
- Running My Own Ship
- The Full Draft - write it all
- Chapter One - shape it
- **This Is Me - the unveiling**

Ends with a story-of-self portfolio and the confidence of knowing where you came from and who you are now.

THE PROBLEM

The Forge

What is worth solving?

JOY: CURIOSITY & COMPANY

- Naming the Dragon
- The Detective - find the root
- My Arena - what you can move
- The Wider Field
- The Long Game
- Hands to Work - service
- **The Call to Action - the talk**

Ends with a problem they chose, real service given, and a public talk that makes a room care.

THE RESOLUTION

The Helm

What do I do when there is no easy answer?

JOY: EXPRESSION & CAMARADERIE

- The Mantle - why you?
- No Easy Answers - dilemmas
- The Ripple - what if?
- The Stage - theatre
- The Arena of Voices - mentors
- The Bridge - leading together
- **The Council - the hard call**

Ends with the capacity to make a hard call from principle, and a real mentor in their corner.

How it works

THE SHAPE

A turning cycle, not a ladder. Three seasons; walk all three before you launch. Join at any season, never behind.

THE WEEK

Two days with a Launch Pad Guide - a life-coach, not a teacher - plus two days of self-directed project work and a protected day for rest, play, and friendship.

THE THREAD

One learner-owned Captain's Log, carried and deepened across all three seasons. It belongs to the learner.

THE SEND-OFF

Your Next Great Adventure - a personal graduation rite in each learner's final year.

THE FLOOR

Learner-led. No grades, no ranking. Joy is woven into the work, never assigned.

What your learner graduates with

Everything a career-prep program promises - and the part those programs leave out.

Ready for the world

- A professional portfolio and resume, with real referrals
- Real professional mentors in a field they care about
- Hundreds of hours of real project, mentorship, and service work
- A signature strength, developed to a level they can show
- Public speaking: a delivered talk and a public council
- Leadership experience - leading peers, not just joining
- Time management, goal-setting, planning, communication
- High-school requirements met along the way

Sure of who they are

- They know who they are and where they came from
- They can make a hard call from principle, not on instruction
- They have faced real moral complexity and can reason through it
- They have friends, a community, and a life they love
- They can take on anything - and they want to

A letter to a builder

Dear builder,

Most of high school asks a teenager to memorize answers to questions they never asked, on a schedule that belongs to the institution and not to them. They graduate able to pass a test and unsure who they are.

I wanted to build the opposite. The Launch Pad Story is three years shaped like a story - the set-up, the problem, the resolution - because a life is a story, and a young person who can author their own can take on anything. In the first year they learn who they are and where they came from. In the second they find a problem worth their effort and do something real about it. In the third they meet the hard calls, the ones with no clean answer, and learn to make them from principle - then step into whatever comes next.

It runs as a cycle, not a ladder. The three years turn like seasons, and a learner walks all of them before they launch, in whatever order their cohort is on. No one is ahead or behind. Two days a week they meet with a guide who is a coach, not a lecturer; two days they captain their own projects. There are no grades and no ranking. There is a great deal of dreaming, real work, hard questions, shared meals, and room to love the life they are living while they build it.

This is the draft of that program. I would be glad to build it with you.

Erin Stanley
Guide, Vibrant Life

Why this works

The shape is warm, and it is also grounded. A few of the findings underneath it.

Near goals build real confidence

Young people grow most when they set near-term goals they choose and reach, each win fueling the courage for the next. That is exactly why the 100 Dreams sort into horizons, and the within-a-year goals lead the season. (Bandura & Schunk)

Mastery beats performance

Learners aimed at mastering something face challenge and recover from setbacks; learners aimed at looking good fall apart under it. We frame everything as mastery, never as ranking. (Dweck)

Projects hold the attention lectures fight

Self-directed, project-based learning is the strongest evidence-based shape for how teenagers actually learn - including the ones who struggle to sit still in a conventional classroom.

Agency is the active ingredient

Across developmental psychology, motivation research, and trauma-informed care, the same finding recurs: remove a learner's agency and any structure turns harmful; protect it and the structure becomes where growth happens. So: learner-led, no grades, no surveillance, and the right to decline.

Learner-led, in good company

The cycle is aligned with the Acton and Hero's Journey model of self-directed, exhibition-based learning - with a story spine and a life-coach guide of its own.

Safety is designed, not assumed

Heavy material is held with previews, opt-outs, and body-first regulation, because pressure and anxiety degrade learning. Care is what lets a young person reach.

How it works, in full

A turning cycle of three seasons, learner-led, with two guided days a week.

A cycle, not a ladder

Origin, The Forge, and The Helm turn like the seasons of a year. Every learner walks all three before they launch, and may join at any point. A learner who starts mid-cycle is joining the story in progress, never behind.

The Guide is a life-coach

Not a teacher who delivers answers. A guide who holds questions, walks alongside, and has permission to say "I don't know - let's find out together." The learner leads.

One Captain's Log

Each learner keeps a single journal, carried and deepened across all three seasons. It belongs to the learner alone, never read for grading - the line they walk through the turning cycle.

Joy is woven in

Roots and belonging, curiosity and company, expression and camaraderie - plus shared meals, expeditions, the arts, and a protected day for rest and play. Joy is invited, never assigned.

The floor

Learner-led and sovereignty-honoring. No grades, no ranking, no busywork. A learner may decline a quest and still be fully honored. Progress belongs to them, not to a scoreboard.

The send-off

Your Next Great Adventure - a personal graduation rite in each learner's final year, whatever season that is. The send-off belongs to the learner, not the calendar.

A day with the Guide, a day on your own

The learner's day runs 9:00 am to 1:30 pm. Two days a week are Launch days with the Guide; two are self-directed project days. Both begin with the learner's own hands.

A Launch day (with the Guide)	
9:00-10:00	**Walk-in & Project Hour** - arrive at your pace; reading, core academics, goal-setting. A soft, working start.
10:00-10:25	**Opening Circle** - settle, then "how are you, really?" Presence before content.
10:25-10:40	**The Quest Frame** - the Guide opens the session's question.
10:40-11:45	**The Work of the Day** - the core activity, which changes each session. Learner-led.
11:45-12:15	**The Table** - a shared meal.
12:15-1:10	**Apply & Collaborate** - carry the quest into hands-on work.
1:10-1:30	**Bridge & Glad Close** - name the next step; close with something light.

A project day (on your own)
Self-set intention - name today's focus.
Deep-work blocks - reading, core / HS requirements, the personal project, the season's writing.
Collaboration - optional; problems are often solved with others.
The Log - capture the day.
On cadence, a fallow day - rest, play, friendship. Protected, never filled.

Opening with a working hour eases learners in through self-direction before the social circle - a gift for the anxious or introverted - and signals that even a guided day is the learner's own.

The Guide

The Launch Pad Guide is a life-coach, not a teacher. The job is not to deliver answers; it is to ask the question under the question, hold the room, and walk alongside a young person while they do their

own becoming. A good guide is comfortable saying "I don't know - let's find out together," because that models exactly what we are trying to grow.

What the Guide does

- Opens with presence before content
- Runs the games and the Socratic frames
- Notices a struggling learner and stays with them
- Protects the floor: no grades, no ranking, no forcing

What the Guide never does

- Lecture, or deliver the meaning ready-made
- Assign and rank
- Push a learner past their own pace
- Read the Captain's Log for assessment

This is real emotional labor, two days a week, across identity, real-world problems, and moral weight. So the plan builds in support for the Guide too: training in coaching and trauma-informed facilitation, peer support, and protected rest. A guide who is depleted cannot hold a room. The one who keeps the door must also be kept.

How we show growth without grades

The most common question: without grades, how do you know a learner is growing - and how do you show a parent?

We make growth visible, just not with a number. Every learner builds a story-of-self portfolio and a one-page resume in the first season, and a body of real work after that - a service project, a public talk, a council. Each season ends in a public exhibition with a real audience: the Unveiling, the Call to Action, the Council. A parent does not get a report card; they get to watch their child stand up and show who they are becoming. The Captain's Log holds the private record of the journey, and it belongs to the learner alone.

High-school requirements are not set aside. Core academics and the credits a learner needs live in the self-directed project days, tracked and met. *[Jenna to confirm: how Vibrant Life issues credit, and the*

diploma or transcript path.] The difference is that the requirements serve the learner's path, instead of the path serving the requirements.

The mixed-age cycle

Because the program is a cycle, learners of different ages share the room, each on a different season. A fifteen-year-old might begin in The Helm while an older learner is in Origin. This is a feature, not a problem: older learners model for younger ones, and younger learners ask the questions older ones have stopped asking.

A learner who joins mid-cycle is joining a story already in progress - welcomed where they are, never treated as behind. Every learner walks all three seasons before they graduate, and the order does not matter, because each season is complete in itself. The one thing they carry the whole way, whatever their entry point, is their own Captain's Log. The seasons turn like a wheel; the learner walks a straight line through it, from the day they arrive to the day they launch.

Inside Origin - the first sessions

Origin asks: **Who am I?** Its joy is roots and belonging. Here are all seven sessions, each on the same two-day shape.

WHAT YOUR LEARNER WALKS AWAY WITH

- A story-of-self portfolio, with a one-page resume inside it
- Real confidence in where they came from and who they are now
- 100 dreams named, and the courage to dream bigger
- Time management, communication, routine, and progress on HS requirements
- The first chapters of their Captain's Log, carried through all three years

SESSION 1 The Map of Me

short, 3 to 4 weeks

FOCUS

The 100 Dreams - dream big, with courage. First sort them by time horizon - more than 5 years out, within 5 years, within 1 year - then map them across all 12 life categories. "The soul never thinks without a picture." All things are created twice, first in the mind; the far dreams are the end to begin with, the near ones become this season's first goals.

WORK OF THE DAY

Write 100 dreams unfiltered; sort by horizon (5+ years / within 5 years / within 1 year); then map across the 12 life categories; a "which dreams scare you?" courage pass.

ON YOUR OWN

Draft the 100 dreams; open the Captain's Log; pick three dreams to orient the season.

JOY

The thrill of permission to dream without a ceiling.

SESSION 2 The Lineage

short, 3 to 4 weeks

FOCUS

The family tree as mythos - the stories of your lineage, gathered the way deep culture is gathered, with the recipes and foods of where you come from.

WORK OF THE DAY

How to gather a story and interview someone you love; a listening model on love and mortality; mapping the family mythos; the family-story potluck.

ON YOUR OWN

Conduct family interviews; gather recipes; write the stories into the Log.

JOY

The potluck feast; the foods and music of lineage; belonging.

CARE

Family means whoever made you - chosen and found family included. Any interview is opt-out, no reason owed. Heavy material is previewed, with a real way to step out.

SESSION 3 The Power of Choice

short, 3 to 4 weeks

FOCUS

Choice as the engine of a life - and the way responsibility, freedom, and choice are one knot, not three topics.

WORK OF THE DAY

Start each day with a choice game; "where did a choice change everything?"

ON YOUR OWN

Choice journaling in the Log; the personal project; goal-setting practice.

JOY

Play - the games are genuinely fun, and agency feels good.

SESSION 4 Running My Own Ship

short, 3 to 4 weeks

FOCUS

Time management, communication, and finishing HS requirements - with a midpoint look back at the season. The frame: routine is not the opposite of freedom; it is what makes freedom possible.

WORK OF THE DAY

Build a routine that fits you; communication practice; "what have these first weeks shown you about yourself?"

ON YOUR OWN

Catch up or get ahead on HS requirements; design your own routine; refine the personal-project plan.

JOY

The quiet satisfaction of a rhythm that fits, and momentum.

SESSION 5 The Full Draft

long, about 6 weeks

FOCUS

Claim your whole life. Write all of it - the autobiography in full, unedited. Nothing is too small. This is the expansion; Session 6 will shape it.

WORK OF THE DAY

Memory prompts (turning points, sensory doorways, the people who made you, your hardest and best days, one ordinary day); listening models of how an ordinary life becomes a story; write it all.

ON YOUR OWN

Write the full draft; read the models; lots of writing time.

JOY

The relief of claiming a whole life, and being witnessed.

CARE

Some lives carry loss; any memory is opt-out.

SESSION 6 Chapter One

long, about 6 weeks

FOCUS

Become the author. A chapter is not a smaller version of your life - it is a shaped thing with a throughline. Shrinking your story to "chapter one" is an act of hope: it says there are chapters still to come.

WORK OF THE DAY

Find the throughline; keep the few load-bearing moments; write Chapter One. The truth-discipline: cut to focus, never to hide - what is left out is kept, not erased.

ON YOUR OWN

Write Chapter One; build the story-of-self portfolio and the one-page resume inside it.

JOY

The craft of shaping, and the hope of chapters to come.

SESSION 7 **This Is Me - The Unveiling** long, harvest

FOCUS

A self-portrait, a "This Is Me" piece. Present who you are - the portfolio, the resume, Chapter One - to a real audience.

WORK OF THE DAY

Make the art piece; prepare the exhibition; the closing "This Is Me" that rhymes with the dreams of Session 1.

ON YOUR OWN

Build the art piece; finalize the portfolio; rehearse the unveiling.

JOY

Being seen by your people; the unveiling feast.

Inside The Forge

The Forge asks: **What is worth solving?** Its joy is curiosity and company - this is where Origin's dreaming becomes building.

WHAT YOUR LEARNER WALKS AWAY WITH

- A real problem they chose because it matters to them
- The skill to name a problem precisely and trace it to its root
- A service or philanthropy project they acted on, with real people
- Experience collaborating and failing forward
- A public Call to Action talk that can move a room

SESSION 1 Naming the Dragon

short, 3 to 4 weeks

FOCUS

The difference nobody hands teenagers - a problem you can act on, a fact of life to accept, a preference you just want, a mystery to sit with. You fight a dragon differently depending which it is.

WORK OF THE DAY

A "problem or not?" sorting game; turning complaints into "how might we" questions; the iceberg of surface problem vs. root.

ON YOUR OWN

Reframe your own complaints into how-might-we questions; Log; reading, core / HS.

JOY

The relief of turning a fog of dread into a thing with a name.

SESSION 2 The Detective

short, 3 to 4 weeks

FOCUS

Investigation as root-cause work - observe, gather evidence, separate symptom from cause, and keep asking why. The obvious culprit is almost never the root.

WORK OF THE DAY

The cohort picks the format - a ready murder mystery, one they build themselves, or an immersive walk-through; solve it; then run the "five whys" on a real problem.

ON YOUR OWN

Run the five whys on a real problem of your own; investigate; Log.

JOY

Company and play; teens love this one.

CARE

Kept light and bloodless, with a gentler "who sabotaged the festival" version on offer.

SESSION 3 My Arena

short, 3 to 4 weeks

FOCUS

Right-sizing. The circles of concern, influence, and control. Energy spent only on worry burns out; the shift is to the arena where your action actually moves something.

WORK OF THE DAY

Map your three circles; take an honest inventory of what you have - skills, time, relationships; choose a small starter quest.

ON YOUR OWN

Act on a small real problem in your arena; Log; core / HS.

JOY

The quiet power of "this one is mine, and I can move it."

SESSION 4 The Wider Field

short, 3 to 4 weeks

FOCUS

Lift your eyes to the world's problems, and choose the one that matters to you - never assigned. The finding question is not "what is important?" but "what breaks your heart?"

WORK OF THE DAY

An expedition to where a real problem lives; a gallery of the world's problems; a first look at who actually has the problem.

ON YOUR OWN

Research your chosen problem; map its stakeholders; commit to the one you carry.

JOY

Curiosity, the wider field, the thing that lights you up.

CARE

Paired with agency so big problems inspire rather than crush - you pick your slice.

SESSION 5 The Long Game

long, about 6 weeks

FOCUS

Can big problems be solved? Things are only impossible until they're not. Big problems are systems, not single acts; you break the impossible into the next doable step, and no one solves them alone.

WORK OF THE DAY

A daily "impossible question"; approaching the too-big through play, curiosity, and facing what's avoided; systems thinking, collaboration, and failing forward.

ON YOUR OWN

Break your big problem into doable steps; prototype; collaborate; Log.

JOY

Play, the company of collaborators, the awe of big questions.

SESSION 6 Hands to Work

long, finish line

FOCUS

Real action on the problem you chose. You choose how you serve - direct service, advocacy, philanthropy, building, or teaching. Chosen service teaches contribution; assigned service only teaches compliance.

WORK OF THE DAY

Pick your mode of service; learn to design with the people who have the problem, not for them; plan and begin.

ON YOUR OWN

Carry out the service or philanthropy project, with real people; Log.

JOY

The warmth of service done together.

CARE

Stretched, not overwhelmed - support around any hard human situations.

SESSION 7 **The Call to Action** long, harvest

FOCUS

Stand and make the case - here is a problem worth solving, here is why it broke my heart, here is what I did, and here is what I ask of you. Advocacy that makes a room care.

WORK OF THE DAY

The talk's shape - problem, stakes, story, the ask; rehearse; the public talk and feast.

ON YOUR OWN

Build and rehearse the talk; finalize the project.

JOY

Being heard; the cohort that has your back.

Inside The Helm

The Helm asks: **What do I do when there is no easy answer?** Its joy is expression and camaraderie. The heaviest season, held with care.

WHAT YOUR LEARNER WALKS AWAY WITH

- The capacity to make a hard call from principle, and live with it
- Practice reasoning through real moral dilemmas, not memorizing answers
- A professional mentor in their field of interest
- Leadership experience: leading peers, and being led well
- A public Council: deliberating a real dilemma before an audience

SESSION 1 The Mantle

short, 3 to 4 weeks

FOCUS

Who are you to solve problems? Why you? Imposter feelings spike now for a reason - they arrive when identity forms and stakes rise. Not a flaw; the feeling of reaching past your current self.

WORK OF THE DAY

Share a time you felt like a fraud (the Guide first); flip "who am I?" into "why not you?"; build a file of real evidence of your competence; step into a role before you feel ready.

ON YOUR OWN

Build your evidence file from the portfolio; Log; reading, core / HS.

JOY

The play of stepping into a role bigger than you feel.

SESSION 2 No Easy Answers

short, 3 to 4 weeks

FOCUS

Moral dilemmas met through story, each tied to a real moment in history. The win is reasoning, not the answer - holding the tension and reasoning from principle.

WORK OF THE DAY

A dilemma story paired with its real historical case; the major ethical frameworks; a discussion that resolves into reasoning, never a tidy verdict.

ON YOUR OWN

Research a paired real case; write your reasoning in the Log; core / HS.

JOY

The thrill of a real argument among friends who stay friends.

CARE

The heaviest themes are previewed, with alternates and opt-out; the story keeps a safe distance from anyone's own life.

SESSION 3 The Ripple

short, 3 to 4 weeks

FOCUS

Consequence-thinking - second and third effects, several moves ahead. Good captains think in ripples, not points; every solution creates new conditions.

WORK OF THE DAY

Map a "what if" outward in waves; the wish that backfires; "what if this had never happened?"; a pre-mortem on the solution you built in The Forge.

ON YOUR OWN

Ripple-map or pre-mortem your own project; Log; core / HS.

JOY

Chasing a cascade to surprising places.

SESSION 4 The Stage

short, 3 to 4 weeks

FOCUS

Theatre as stepping into another life, especially a hard one. The stage's distance is a safety feature - you can be the person who makes the other choice.

WORK OF THE DAY

Our Town and its question of whether we ever realize life while we live it; a monologue from someone facing a hard call; archetypes as doorways; acting out a dilemma and trying a different choice.

ON YOUR OWN

Find or write a monologue; rehearse; reading, core / HS.

JOY

Expression; the play of becoming someone else for an hour.

CARE

Roles are chosen, opt-out always, and a ritual to step cleanly out of a heavy character.

SESSION 5 The Arena of Voices

long, about 6 weeks

FOCUS

Finding and working with a real professional mentor in the field you've been circling. Being mentored is a threshold - being seen by someone you admire.

WORK OF THE DAY

Mentor matching; the real skill of being mentored - how to reach out, ask a question worth a busy person's time, follow up; the informational interview; the pitch.

ON YOUR OWN

Reach out to a mentor; conduct informational interviews; prepare the pitch.

JOY

The company of someone further down a road you want to walk.

SESSION 6 The Bridge

long, finish line

FOCUS

Leading peers. Leadership is stewardship, not command - the measure of a leader is what continues when they step back. Lead toward your own unnecessity.

WORK OF THE DAY

Everyone takes a turn leading; find your own style; the hard parts - feedback, the unpopular call, holding a group through conflict; expedition leadership.

ON YOUR OWN

Lead a real group task; reflect on leading and following; Log.

JOY

Camaraderie; the fellowship of leading together.

SESSION 7 **The Council** long, harvest

FOCUS

A council is not a debate - it has discernment. Reason out loud around a real dilemma, in front of your people: not performing certainty, but holding tension without collapsing it.

WORK OF THE DAY

Deliberate a real dilemma in public; act it out, then council it; a leader holds the room; the feast.

ON YOUR OWN

Prepare the council case; rehearse leadership; finalize.

JOY

Being witnessed reasoning honestly about something that matters.

Questions you might have

What about college?

A portfolio, a body of real work, three years of public exhibitions, and a young person who can speak clearly about who they are and what they have done is a strong college story. *[Jenna to confirm: any college-counseling or transcript specifics.]*

What about a diploma and credits?

Core academics and required credits are met during the project days, tracked alongside the learner's own work. *[Jenna to confirm: diploma and transcript path.]* The requirements serve the learner, not the reverse.

What if a learner refuses a quest?

The right to decline is built in and honored, never coded as failure. A learner who steps back is met, not pushed. Refusal is information, and often the start of the real conversation.

The third year sounds heavy. Is it safe?

Yes, by design. Moral dilemmas are met through story and history, never personal confession; the hardest themes are previewed with alternates and opt-outs; every session opens with regulation. The distance is the safety feature.

How big is a cohort, and how many guides?

The model assumes a small cohort and a guide who can hold a real relationship with every learner. *[Jenna to confirm: cohort size and guide-to-learner ratio.]*

What does a parent actually see?

The outcomes promised at the start of each season, three public exhibitions a year, and a young person who comes home more themselves. Not a report card - a person.

What this draws on

THE BACKGROUND BEHIND THIS DRAFT

This program draws on a Professional Life Coach certification and guide training, fifteen years of improv coaching (presence, group dynamics, structured spontaneity), a B.A. in Psychology and a Marriage and Family Therapy degree in progress, and twelve years building training systems and leading teams through change - alongside a year of guiding at Vibrant Life, watching closely what these learners actually need.

A closing invitation

This is a draft, and a living one. The shape is here - three seasons, a turning cycle, a guide who coaches, work that is real, and joy woven through. What is not here yet is everything we would decide together: the calendar, the cohort, the credits, the thousand small choices that make a program into a place. I would be glad to build those with you.

Let's set the next great adventure in motion.